The War from the North

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Same war, two stories

In the United States, the War of 1812 is the war of the Star-Spangled Banner — the flag still flying over Fort McHenry at dawn. It is a story of a young nation standing up to an empire.

Cross the border, and the very same war is remembered as something else entirely: an American invasion, turned back by the people who lived there. In Canada it is often called the war that made the country — the moment British North America decided it would not become part of the United States.

The Battle of Queenston Heights, 13 October 1812 — a British, Canadian, and Mohawk victory on the Niagara frontier. Period illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

“A mere matter of marching”

Why would the United States invade its northern neighbor? The reasons Americans gave were real: the British navy was seizing American sailors — a practice called impressment — British rules were strangling American trade, and Britain was arming Indigenous resistance on the frontier. Some American “War Hawks” also simply wanted the land.

But from the northern side of the border, the cause mattered less than the fact: American armies were marching on Upper Canada and Lower Canada. To the farmers, soldiers, and First Nations living there, 1812 was not a debate over sailors’ rights. It was an invasion to be survived.

The theatre of war

Almost the whole war was fought along one thin ribbon of water: the Great Lakes and the rivers that join them. Whoever controlled the lakes controlled how armies and supplies could move — so the border, the lakes, and the short rivers between them became the battlefield.

Three places carried much of the story. At Detroit, where Lake Erie drains toward Lake Huron, Brock and Tecumseh won the opening victory. On the Niagara — the narrow neck between Lake Erie and Lake Ontario — the two sides clashed again and again, including at Queenston Heights. And after the Americans burned York, today’s Toronto, on Lake Ontario, the British marched south and burned Washington in return.

The War of 1812 in the north — the Great Lakes theatre. Map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection); base coastlines public domain.

Mackinac

The war's first action in the west came before any battle on the Niagara. On the seventeenth of July, 1812, a British officer, a handful of regulars, and a large force of fur traders and First Nations warriors crossed to Mackinac Island and trained a single cannon on the American fort. Taken completely by surprise, the garrison surrendered without firing a shot.

It was a small fort in a remote place, but the effect was huge. The bloodless capture of Mackinac signalled to the Indigenous nations of the Great Lakes that the British might actually win — and it brought many of them, including Tecumseh's followers, firmly onto the British side just as the fighting began.

Mackinac Island and its fort, on the straits between Lakes Huron and Michigan. Engraving, public domain (source to confirm).

The invasions that failed

Three American thrusts crossed into Canada in 1812 — at Detroit, across the Niagara River, and toward Montreal. All three failed.

At Detroit, the British general Isaac Brock and the Shawnee leader Tecumseh bluffed a larger American force into surrendering without a real fight. Brock paraded his troops to look like thousands; Tecumseh's warriors slipped through the woods in plain view and out again. Convinced he was hopelessly outnumbered, the American commander gave up Detroit — a stunning opening victory for the defenders.

General William Hull surrenders Detroit to the British, August 1812. Engraving, public domain (source to confirm).

Sir Isaac Brock

To English-speaking Canada, Isaac Brock became the hero of the war: bold, fast, and willing to gamble. The capture of Detroit made his name on both sides of the Atlantic.

He would not live to see the war's end. Within two months, defending the Niagara frontier, Brock was dead — and in dying he became something more useful to a young country than a living general: a martyr and a legend.

Major-General Sir Isaac Brock (1769–1812). Portrait, public domain (source to confirm).

Queenston Heights

At dawn American troops crossed the Niagara River and seized the heights above the village of Queenston. Brock rushed to the sound of the guns and led a charge straight up the slope — and was shot through the chest, dying almost at once.

But the day was not lost. British regulars, Canadian militia, and Mohawk warriors under John Norton fought their way back up the heights and forced the Americans to surrender. The invasion of the Niagara had failed, and Brock's death sealed his legend.

Brock's Monument on Queenston Heights, Ontario, marks the battlefield and Brock's grave. Photograph, public domain / © ShadowDog Digital Studios if newly taken (source to confirm).

Tecumseh

For Tecumseh and the confederacy of nations he was building, 1812 was never about Canada or the United States. It was about one thing: stopping the flood of American settlers onto Indigenous land. The British were allies of convenience — the one power that might help hold the line.

Tecumseh was killed at the Battle of the Thames in 1813. With him died the confederacy and the dream of an independent Indigenous homeland in the Great Lakes country. This is the part of the war that both national stories tend to hurry past.

Tecumseh (c. 1768–1813), Shawnee leader of a pan-Indigenous confederacy. Portrait, public domain (source to confirm).

War on the water

The Great Lakes were the highways of this war, and both sides raced to build fleets on them. Whoever ruled the water could move armies and supplies; whoever lost it could not hold the shore.

The turning point came on Lake Erie. In September 1813 the American commander Oliver Hazard Perry destroyed the British squadron and reported, “We have met the enemy and they are ours.” With the lake lost, the British could no longer supply their forces in the west — and had to retreat, giving up the ground Brock and Tecumseh had won the year before.

A squadron on the Great Lakes. Illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

The Thames

Retreating up the Thames River in what is now southwestern Ontario, the British and their First Nations allies turned to fight near Moraviantown. The British line broke quickly. Tecumseh stayed, fought, and was killed.

With his death the confederacy came apart. The dream of an independent Indigenous homeland in the Great Lakes country — the thing Tecumseh had fought the whole war to win — died with him. It is one of the war’s most important consequences, and the one both national stories hurry past the fastest.

The Battle of the Thames (Moraviantown), where Tecumseh was killed, 1813. Lithograph, public domain (source to confirm).

Laura Secord’s walk

With American troops occupying the Niagara peninsula, Laura Secord overheard officers planning a surprise attack. She set out on foot and walked some thirty kilometres through swamp and woods to warn the British officer James FitzGibbon.

Forewarned, FitzGibbon’s small force — and the Kahnawà:ke and Mohawk warriors who did most of the actual fighting — won the Battle of Beaver Dams. Secord became one of Canada’s most famous historical figures, remembered on stamps, statues, and even a box of chocolates. The warriors who won the battle are remembered far less.

Laura Secord (1775–1868). Portrait, public domain (source to confirm).

Châteauguay & Crysler’s Farm

In the autumn of 1813 the Americans aimed a two-pronged advance at Montreal. At Châteauguay, Charles de Salaberry and a few hundred French-Canadian voltigeurs and Mohawk allies turned back a

force many times their size. Weeks later, at Crysler's Farm, British regulars did the same along the St. Lawrence.

French Canadians were fighting to defend their own homes and way of life, not to serve an empire they had little love for. That is part of why the memory of 1812 runs across both English and French Canada — two peoples who otherwise agreed on very little.

The Battle of Châteauguay, 26 October 1813. Illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

A capital for a capital

In April 1813, American forces captured York — today's Toronto — and burned the Parliament buildings of Upper Canada to the ground.

In August 1814, a British army marched into Washington and burned the Capitol and the President's House in return. To Canadians, the burning of the American capital was simple justice for the burning of York and the town of Niagara. The same fire is a humiliation in one country's memory and a vindication in the other's.

The ruins of the President's House after the British burning of Washington, August 1814. Illustration, public domain (source to confirm).

Who won?

The Treaty of Ghent ended the war with no change to the border at all — status quo ante bellum, the way things were before. Every army went home to the line it had started from.

And yet everyone declared victory. Americans called it a "second war of independence" and celebrated survival against an empire. Canadians took it as proof they had thrown back an invasion and would never be American — a founding story. Indigenous nations, left out of the treaty entirely, had lost their greatest leader, their confederacy, and any hope of a homeland of their own.

The war that 'made Canada'

Canada long remembered 1812 as the war where plucky local militia rose up and saved the country. Historians point out that most of the hard fighting was done by British regulars and by First Nations allies — the so-called "militia myth" flattened a messy, many-sided war into a tidy national origin story.

That is worth noticing, because it is how all national memory works. Monuments, textbooks, anniversaries — even chocolate boxes — quietly decide which parts of a war a country keeps and which it lets fade. Memory is made, not found.

Whose story gets told?

Historians call this skill historical perspective: recognizing that the same events look different depending on where you stand. Queenston Heights is a glorious victory from one side of the river, a bungled invasion from the other, and, for the Mohawk who held the hill, a fight for a homeland that neither empire would ultimately protect.

You have already seen the American telling in The Anthem. Now you have seen the view from the north. Weigh the perspectives against one another — then decide who really “won” the War of 1812, and for whom.